

HOME VIEW

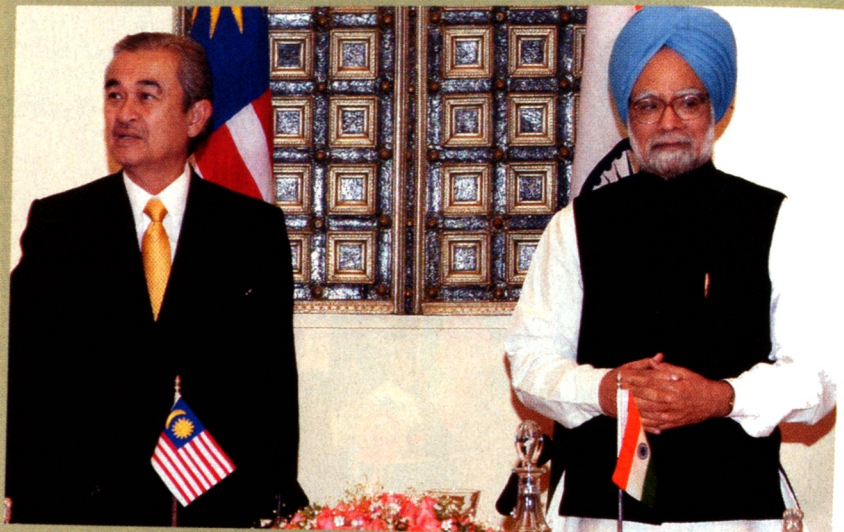
A Difficult Balancing Act

It empathises with the plight of ethnic Indians in Malaysia but India can't be seen as interfering

The diplomatic tit for tat between India and Malaysia over the Tamil protest has brought to the fore the delicate relationship India has with the South-East Asian nation. While the protest by Hindu Tamils was prompted by the Malaysian regime's domestic policy of favouring Malays and Muslims at the cost of ethnic Chinese and Hindu minorities, it has had a spill-over effect on domestic politics in India.

"Whenever Indian citizens abroad or people of Indian origin living abroad are adversely affected, it becomes a source of concern for us," remarked Prime Minister Manmohan Singh. His statement reinforced the fact that diplomatic policies have to be in tune with domestic policies. As pressure mounts on the Government with Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi seeking the prime minister's intervention, the issue has also rocked Parliament. The Foreign Office has taken up the matter with the Malaysian High Commission in Delhi. But the Malaysian response has fallen short of addressing India's concerns. In line with their public riposte to Karunanidhi advising him to mind his own business, Malaysians have told the Indians to lay off as it is a matter concerning ethnic Indians most of whom are Malaysian nationals.

Legally and diplomatically, while India can do little as the protesters hold Malaysian nationality, the problem is much bigger. India's



THE BIG DIVIDE: Manmohan with Badawi (left) in Delhi

dilemma is that while on one hand it does not want to be seen as interfering in another country's internal affairs, it cannot ignore the sentiments of its own Tamil population also.

Diplomatic sources say that even when it comes to enforcing the rights of Indian workers, New Delhi finds it hard to break through the Malaysian bureaucracy, that continues to practice its discriminatory Bhumiputra policy. Malaysia, which is a member of the Commonwealth and the Non-Aligned Movement, has never had a cosy relationship with India because of its active support of arch-enemy Islamabad at international forums like oic (Organisation of the Islamic Conference). The assessment here is that Malaysian Prime Minister

Badawi is keen to repair the relationship with ties growing and bilateral trade touching US \$7 billion (Rs 27,545 crore) but mistrust continues. Differences remain on economic issues such as the reduction of tariffs on palm oil exports which have held up the India-ASEAN free trade agreement. On the visa issue too, Malaysia is considered a difficult customer. If the standoff continues, it will only add to the distance between the two.

As India's global clout grows, so will the demand from the Indian diaspora seeking the help of the mother country in the case of a crisis. This is a good opportunity for India to strengthen the ties of economic and political engagement, which can provide it diplomatic leverage when its diaspora is in trouble.

by Saurabh Shukla

cent in the same period."

Some of the blame is also being laid at the feet of fundamentalist Islam. "Being voiceless, we are at the receiving end of fundamentalism, which has spread its wings in the Government and almost become an official policy," said Ponnusamy. He alleges that this is the reason why some 500 of the 17,000 temples in the country have been demolished since 2004. Aziz disagrees, saying shortsighted officials were

involved, who were insensitive out of ignorance. "It is not government policy to demolish temples. That is rubbish. We gave millions to construct temples, why should we destroy them?"

It is clear that the Government cannot ignore the protest, says Lim. "The Government has to offer a comprehensive 'new deal' for Indians that covers all areas of grievances—jobs, temples, schools and above all, the creation of opportunities. It has to

build confidence and a sense of belonging among the Tamil masses," he said. "Theirs is a cry of desperation, they want to belong. They don't want to be excluded." While Malaysia grapples with its ethnic anger, Tamils—both in Malaysia and Tamil Nadu—will be watching India. It will be a tight balancing act for New Delhi—between showing concern for Tamils and convincing the Malay majority that it is not interfering in their internal matter. ■